# Sycamore Square — Four Development Options Compared

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## Summary

This compares five ways to use the building, in plain money terms: what it costs to get open, what comes in and goes out each year, and how many years it takes to earn the money back. A typical investment property earns back in about 12 years. The goal here is 10 years or less. Building costs are at Memphis prices, with the ownership group managing the work and hiring each trade directly rather than handing the whole job to one general contractor. Every number includes buying the property at an assumed price of $3.0M, plus fees, closing costs, surveys and inspections.

- **On today's realistic numbers, the efficient full plan comes closest, but it is still slower than a typical property.** Buying at an assumed $3.0M, with 220 hall events a year (about 4 a week across both halls), it costs about $15.2M all in and makes about $1.07M profit a year: about 14 years to earn the money back. The hybrid takes about 15½ years, the full plan as drawn about 16½, the lean plan about 17½ and leasing everything about 23½.
- **The halls make or break the project.** The two halls bring in about $2.68M a year and keep about $724k after their own staff, food and running costs. Everything else (shops, flex space, the kids' center and the fuel pad) adds about $347k a year on top.
- **Hall prices now come from Memphis rate cards.** Comparable halls ask about $7,000–9,000 for a 300–400 guest Saturday (The Palace at Cordova $7,000, The Columns $8,550, the Cadre Building $12,200), with Fridays and Sundays at about 80% of that and weekdays at about 60%. The realistic case averages $5,500 per event across all days and adds the 20% service charge Memphis venues put on catering, half of it paid to event staff.
- **Bookings move the numbers most.** One more event a week across the halls adds about $295k of profit a year; $1,000 more per booking adds about $176k.
- **Building it trade by trade saves real money.** If one general contractor did the whole job, the efficient plan would cost about $1.8M more and take about 15.7 years instead of 14.2 to earn back. Code-required work (sprinklers, the voice fire alarm, kitchen hoods, restroom counts, heating and air for large crowds, structural engineering) stays in full either way.
- **Opening up the halls costs about $0.7M.** Removing the 4 columns inside the two hall rooms with steel beams is budgeted at about $175k per column, with the ownership group hiring the steel fabricator and structural engineer directly. Delivered by a general contractor at national prices, the same work runs about $275k per column. A structural engineer must confirm it.
- **Each main room gets a movable wall.** The average wedding has about 117 guests and most Memphis halls hold 100–350, so each 11,000 SF room can split into two for 150–350 guest events. That is what makes 220 events a year realistic; without it, bookings could stay near 120–160 a year.
- **A real path to profit exists.** One more event a week, $1,000 more per booking, $60k less year-round staff, resealing instead of repaving the parking lot, and caterers bringing their own kitchen equipment bring the efficient plan to about 8.8 years at a $3.0M price with open, column-free halls (8.3 years if the columns stay). The hybrid reaches about 9.0 years (8.7 if Hall A's columns stay).

- **Recommended path:** aim for the efficient full plan, but start with the hybrid. Build Hall A, its kitchen, the dining room and the kids' center first, lease the rest as-is, and build Hall B only after Hall A proves about 100 or more events a year. That keeps about $2.6M of Hall B work off the table until the demand is real.
- **Two risks need answers before any commitment.** The worst case loses money every year in every hall plan (slow bookings and higher costs together). And if the halls are approved for very large chairs-only crowds, the building can fall under a stricter earthquake standard that could cost more than the column work. Capping each hall's posted capacity should avoid it; the City and a structural engineer should confirm.

A layout alternative is under study: the same program flipped, with the halls at the north end (Hall A entering from the north lot off Pleasant View Rd, Hall B from the east lot) and the stores at the south end. It costs and earns about the same; the choice comes down to how far apart the two hall entrances are (useful when two events run at once), store visibility and flood exposure.

## The four plans

All the plans buy the same four parcels and keep the existing building. They differ in how much is built at once and who runs what. In every plan with halls, the owners' operating company runs Hall A and Hall B, a playground operator leases the kids' center, and a fuel company ground-leases the fuel pad. A fifth line, "Lease everything", shows the same building with every space leased, including the halls to an outside operator, so the owners can see what running the halls themselves is worth. In every plan the ownership group manages the building work itself and hires each trade directly.

| Plan | What gets built | Opens in | Who runs what |
|---|---|---|---|
| **1. Full plan (as drawn)** | Everything at once: Hall A and Hall B with twin kitchens and dining, the 18,000 SF kids' playground, about 22 small shops, flex space split for tenants, and the fuel pad. The 4 columns inside the two hall rooms are removed with steel beams, and each main room gets a movable wall so it can host one large event or two 150–350 guest events | About 18 months | Owners' operating company: halls. Tenants: shops, flex, kids' center, fuel |
| **2. Full plan, built efficiently** | Same final uses, built leaner: 12 larger shop bays instead of 22; flex left open until leased; roof repaired and coated where sound instead of replaced; heating and air replaced only for the halls and kids' center; existing restrooms reused where possible; hall furniture and kitchen equipment leased; the kids' operator pays for its own fit-out. The 4 hall columns are removed with steel beams, and the movable walls stay | About 15 months | Same as plan 1 |
| **3. Hybrid (phased)** | Phase 1: Hall A with its movable wall, Kitchen A, the dining room and the kids' center. The other 81,000 SF or so, including the future Hall B, is leased as-is on short leases. Phase 2 (realistic: year 3): Hall B and Kitchen B, once Hall A books about 100 events a year. Shop fronts are cut only when tenants sign | About 10 months for phase 1 | Owners' operating company: halls. Tenants: kids' center, as-is space, fuel |
| **4. Lean hold** | No halls yet. Repair the roof, heating and air, fire systems and parking; split the building into 3–6 large blocks; lease them as-is to service, showroom, church, school, medical or back-office users; ground-lease the fuel pad. The halls stay an option for later | About 6 months | Tenants only |
| **For comparison: lease everything** | The full program, but an outside operator leases the halls and pays rent | About 18 months | Tenants only |

Plan 3 is the meeting point of the two ideas. It opens the first hall within a year, but it leaves Hall B and the shop fronts until demand is proven.

## Results: what it costs, what it makes, how long to earn back

Each plan is shown in three cases. The worst, realistic and best cases use different costs, rents and hall bookings, and the same assumed purchase price of $3.0M. "Money in" covers buying the property (plus fees, closing costs, surveys and inspections), the building work, the hall fit-out, design, contingency and leasing costs, and holding costs while building. "Profit each year" is the money coming in minus the money going out once everything is open and settled, before any loan payments.

| Plan | Money in, buying and building (worst / **realistic** / best) | Profit each year | Years to earn back | Profit each year for every $100 spent |
|---|---|---|---|---|
| **Full plan, built efficiently** | $23.0M / **$15.2M** / $10.8M | −$261k / **$1.07M** / $2.54M | never / **14.2** / 4.2 | −$1.14 / **$7.05** / $23.59 |
| **Hybrid (Hall B in year 3)** | $17.3M / **$13.9M** / $9.9M | −$313k / **$903k** / $2.33M | never / **15.3** / 4.2 | −$1.81 / **$6.52** / $23.60 |
| **Full plan (as drawn)** | $28.2M / **$18.5M** / $12.6M | −$200k / **$1.11M** / $2.50M | never / **16.6** / 5.0 | −$0.71 / **$6.01** / $19.91 |
| **Lean hold** | $9.5M / **$6.8M** / $5.5M | −$11k / **$388k** / $837k | never / **17.5** / 6.5 | −$0.12 / **$5.73** / $15.34 |
| **Lease everything (comparison)** | $23.2M / **$15.1M** / $10.5M | $299k / **$638k** / $1.27M | 77.7 / **23.6** / 8.2 | $1.29 / **$4.23** / $12.13 |

**Hybrid, phase 1 only (before Hall B):** money in $17.3M / **$11.3M** / $8.3M; profit each year −$313k / **$504k** / $1.45M; earns back never / **22.4** / 5.7 years. Hall B adds about $2.6M in year 3 in the realistic case. In the worst case Hall B is never built, so the hybrid's worst figures above are phase 1 alone.

### Buying at an assumed $3.0M, the hall plans take about 14 to 16½ years to earn back

Years to earn back all the money in (buying and building). Grey bar: best case to worst case. Dot: realistic case.




Sycamore Square model v2.4, 18 Oct 2026 · worst / realistic / best cases · buying at an assumed $3.0M plus fees and closing

The best cases earn back in about 4 to 8 years (4 to 5 in the hall plans), which is why the project is tempting. The worst cases never earn back in any hall plan, which is why it needs evidence before money is committed.

**If one general contractor did everything.** The figures above assume the ownership group manages the work and hires each trade directly. Handing the whole job to one general contractor adds its overhead and profit, typically 11–22% of the building work (realistic case, Memphis prices):

| Plan | Money to build it: trade by trade | One general contractor | Difference | Years to earn back: trade by trade | One general contractor |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|
| **Full plan, built efficiently** | $15.2M | $17.0M | $1.8M | 14.2 | 15.7 |
| **Hybrid (Hall B in year 3)** | $13.9M | $15.5M | $1.7M | 15.3 | 17.1 |
| **Full plan (as drawn)** | $18.5M | $20.8M | $2.3M | 16.6 | 18.6 |
| **Lean hold** | $6.8M | $7.2M | $0.4M | 17.5 | 18.4 |
| **Lease everything (comparison)** | $15.1M | $16.8M | $1.8M | 23.6 | 26.4 |

## Where the money comes from and where it goes each year (realistic)

This is the realistic case once everything is open and settled. The hall numbers assume 220 events a year across both halls (about 4 a week), reached in the third year of operation; an average room rental of $5,500 across all days (Saturdays higher, weekdays lower, after off-peak and late-date discounts); in-house catering at 55% of events for about 300 guests at $32 a head, plus a 20% service charge on catering, half of it paid to event staff; and a $750 kitchen fee when a customer brings their own caterer.

| Each year | Full plan, built efficiently | Hybrid (after Hall B opens) |
|---|---|---|
| **Money coming in** | | |
| Shop rents | $335k | – |
| Flex space rents | $125k | – |
| Rents from as-is space | – | $256k |
| Kids' center rent | $81k | $81k |
| Fuel pad ground rent | $95k | $95k |
| Tenants repay their share of tax, insurance and upkeep | $213k | $184k |
| Hall bookings: room rental | $1.21M | $1.21M |
| Hall bookings: catering | $1.16M | $1.16M |
| Hall bookings: service charge on catering | $232k | $232k |
| Hall bookings: kitchen fees from outside caterers | $74k | $74k |
| **Total coming in** | **$3.53M** | **$3.29M** |
| **Money going out** | | |
| Allowance for empty-space gaps and unpaid rent | $19k | $13k |
| Property tax | $141k | $94k |
| Insurance, including flood | $89k | $89k |
| Upkeep: parking lot, lighting, landscaping, common areas | $179k | $179k |

| Each year | Full plan, built efficiently | Hybrid (after Hall B opens) |
|---|---|---|
| **Property management** | $41k | $30k |
| **Set-aside for roof and AC repairs** | $32k | $32k |
| **Halls: food for catered events** | $360k | $360k |
| **Halls: catering staff** | $325k | $325k |
| **Halls: service charge paid to event staff** | $116k | $116k |
| **Halls: event-day staff (setup, cleaning, security)** | $264k | $264k |
| **Halls: card fees, marketing, supplies, repairs** | $268k | $268k |
| **Halls: year-round staff, utilities, insurance, equipment lease** | $621k | $621k |
| **Total going out** | **$2.46M** | **$2.39M** |
| **Profit each year, before loan payments** | **$1.07M** | **$903k** |

Before Hall B opens, the hybrid makes about $504k a year. Hall A alone books about 100 events and keeps about $206k after its own costs, and the future Hall B space earns as-is rent in the meantime.

| Other plans, each year | Money coming in | Money going out | Profit each year |
|---|---|---|---|
| **Full plan (as drawn)** | $3.58M | $2.47M | $1.11M |
| **Lean hold** | $846k | $458k | $388k |
| **Lease everything (comparison)** | $1.18M | $544k | $638k |

- **Full plan:** the halls own their furniture and kitchen equipment instead of leasing it. Their running costs therefore include a 3% set-aside to replace that equipment ($348k in the card fees, marketing, supplies and repairs line), while the year-round line is lower ($561k).
- **Lean hold:** all of the income is rent: about 86,000 SF of as-is space at $5.75/SF (70% of the building leased), plus the fuel pad.
- **Lease everything:** an outside hall operator could afford only about $2/SF a year in rent after earning a fair return on its own fit-out. The halls then bring in about $95k a year of rent, against about $724k of profit when the owners run them.

## The one-time money, item by item (realistic)

Everything that has to be paid before the plan is open and settled, buying at an assumed $3.0M. Building items are at Memphis prices, with the ownership group hiring each trade directly.

| One-time item | Efficient | Hybrid | Lean | Full | Lease everything |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|
| **Purchase price (assumed)** | $3.00M | $3.00M | $3.00M | $3.00M | $3.00M |
| **Fees, closing, surveys and inspections** | $265k | $265k | $265k | $265k | $265k |
| **Roof** | $467k | $467k | $431k | $727k | $727k |
| **Heating and air conditioning** | $614k | $417k | $307k | $921k | $921k |

| One-time item | Efficient | Hybrid | Lean | Full | Lease everything |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|
| **Sprinklers** | $258k | $219k | $70k | $300k | $300k |
| **Fire alarm (voice evacuation for large crowds)** | $450k | $407k | $117k | $450k | $450k |
| **Demolition inside the building** | $282k | $172k | $78k | $350k | $350k |
| **New shop fronts** | $301k | – | – | $551k | $551k |
| **New entrances and canopies** | $352k | $235k | $94k | $470k | $470k |
| **Walls between tenants** | $207k | $190k | $225k | $533k | $533k |
| **Restrooms** | $587k | $376k | $117k | $783k | $783k |
| **Electrical** | $407k | $313k | $157k | $470k | $470k |
| **Plumbing** | $172k | $125k | $47k | $196k | $196k |
| **Parking lot repair and repaving** | $431k | $431k | $258k | $449k | $449k |
| **Site work and landscaping** | $235k | $219k | $117k | $313k | $313k |
| **Outside walls and paint** | $235k | $196k | $117k | $313k | $313k |
| **Stormwater detention** | $78k | $78k | – | $78k | $78k |
| **Flood compliance** | $196k | $196k | $196k | $196k | $196k |
| **Removing the hall columns (steel beams)** | $700k (4) | $350k (2) | – | $700k (4) | $700k (4) |
| **Movable walls that split each main room** | $235k | $117k | – | $235k | – |
| **Hall and kitchen fit-out** | $3.43M | $2.01M | – | $3.93M | – |
| **Design, permits and contingency (unknowns)** | $1.06M | $767k | $397k | $1.53M | $1.48M |
| **Tenant fit-out help and leasing commissions** | $747k | $503k | $621k | $1.14M | $1.90M |
| **Holding costs and loan interest while building** | $491k | $244k | $164k | $569k | $641k |
| **Hall B and Kitchen B in year 3 (incl. its movable wall and 2 more columns)** | – | $2.57M | – | – | – |
| **Total** | **$15.19M** | **$13.86M** | **$6.78M** | **$18.47M** | **$15.09M** |
| **Total, not counting the purchase** | $11.93M | $10.60M | $3.51M | $15.21M | $11.82M |
| **If one general contractor did everything (not counting the purchase)** | $13.70M | $12.28M | $3.89M | $17.49M | $13.58M |

- **Building items** cover the whole 127,634 SF building. The efficient and hybrid plans repair and coat the roof where it is sound, replace heating and air only where the halls and kids' center need it, and reuse restroom cores.

- **Memphis prices, trade by trade.** National cost-guide prices are multiplied by 0.89 (the RSMeans 2025 city cost index for Memphis is 89.4) and then taken about 12% below a general contractor's price, because the ownership group manages the job and hires each trade itself (5% in the worst case, 18% in the best). Code-required work stays in full: sprinklers, the voice fire alarm, hoods and grease trap, restroom counts, heating and air sized for large crowds, and structural engineering.
- **Removing the hall columns** is carried at about $175k per column (range $85k–300k). That covers new steel beams about 89 ft long, temporary supports while each column comes out, stronger footings under the columns that pick up the extra load, special inspection and engineering, at Memphis prices with no general contractor's fee. Delivered by a general contractor at national prices, the mid estimate is about $275k per column; the closest documented job cost about $207k–480k per column.
- **Movable walls** are an allowance of about $117k per main room for an acoustic folding wall that splits the room in two. A supplier quote should confirm it.
- **Hall and kitchen fit-out** covers finishes, ceilings, lighting, sound, flooring and the two kitchens (hoods, grease trap and equipment). That is about $55/SF for the hall areas and $235/SF for the kitchens in the efficient plan, and $63 and $274 in the full plan, where the equipment is bought rather than leased.
- **Design, permits and contingency** is 7% for design and permits plus a 10% cushion for surprises on the building items in the efficient plan (7% plus 12% in the full plan). The cushion is not reduced for managing the work directly: that moves coordination risk onto the owners.
- **The range is wide.** The efficient plan's one-time money is $23.0M in the worst case and $10.8M in the best case. Inspections of the roof, heating and air, and structure by the trades that would do the work would narrow it more than anything else.

## What drags the profit down

These figures are for the efficient full plan in the realistic case unless another plan is named.

- **The building work is large next to the rents it unlocks.** The efficient plan spends about $6.2M on the building itself before any hall finishes: roof, heating and air, fire systems, restrooms, electrical, entrances, parking, flood work, the $0.7M of column beams and the movable walls. The shops and flex space it readies bring in about $459k a year of rent.
- **The hall fit-out is the second-biggest check.** It is about $3.4M for finishes, lighting and two kitchens ($3.9M in the full plan). The halls keep about $724k a year after their own staff, food and running costs, so the fit-out alone takes about 4½ years of hall profit to repay.
- **The halls carry heavy fixed costs.** They spend about $621k a year on managers, sales staff, utilities, insurance and leased equipment, plus about $268k on card fees, marketing, supplies and repairs. Those costs run whether the halls are busy or not, and the halls only break even at about 102 events a year.
- **The owners pay building costs on space that pays no rent.** Tax, insurance and upkeep for the whole property come to about $408k a year, and tenants repay about $213k of it. The other $196k or so falls on the owners, mostly for the owner-run hall space (about 37% of the building) and for empty space.
- **Rents are low for the space being prepared.** Shops rent for about $12.50/SF, flex space for about $6.50/SF and as-is space for about $5.75/SF. New shop fronts, walls between tenants and tenant fit-out help cost about $1.0M, against about $335k a year of shop rent.
- **The extras add up.** Design, permits and the contingency cushion ($1.06M), leasing help and commissions ($0.75M), and holding costs and interest while building ($0.49M) add about $2.3M.
- **The fuel pad may not happen.** The plans count $95k a year of ground rent from a fuel company. At realistic volumes that company would keep only about $4 a year for every $100 it spends on a roughly

$3.8M station, so a deal is not assured. Without the fuel and food pads, the efficient plan's payback stretches from about 14 to about 15 years, and the lean plan's from about 17½ to about 22 years.

## Ways to make more or spend less

Each line changes one thing in the realistic case and shows what happens to the profit, the one-time money and the years to earn back. They are not all possible at once. The combined path at the end picks the ones that can go together.

**Full plan, built efficiently.** Today: $1.07M profit a year on $15.19M; earns back in 14.2 years.

| Change (one at a time) | Profit each year | One-time money | Earns back in | Note |
|---|---|---|---|---|
| **One more event a week across the halls (+52 a year)** | +$295k | +$87k | 11.2 yrs | Weddings, engagements, corporate and community events |
| **Charge $1,000 more per hall booking** | +$176k | +$84k | 12.3 yrs | Comparable Memphis halls ask $7,000–9,000 on a Saturday; premium venues $10,000–12,000 |
| **Cater 10% more of the events in-house** | +$60k | +$29k | 13.5 yrs | In-house catering earns more than an outside-caterer kitchen fee |
| **Charge $5 more per guest for catering** | +$63k | +$30k | 13.4 yrs | Memphis buffets run $18–35 per guest and plated meals $28–52 |
| **Run the halls with $60,000 less year-round staff** | +$53k | +$25k | 13.5 yrs | Owner-managed, with part-time event staff |
| **Shops 95% leased instead of 85%** | +$41k | +$79k | 13.7 yrs | Needs strong anchors or a busy hall complex |
| **Kids' center pays $6.00/SF instead of $4.50** | +$22k | +$23k | 13.9 yrs | Depends on the playground operator's sales |
| **Add a food pad on Summer Ave (about $70,000 a year of ground rent)** | +$57k | +$60k | 13.5 yrs | Needs a restaurant tenant and the 5800/5810 Summer pads |
| **Keep the hall columns and decorate around them** | – | −$819k | 13.4 yrs | Saves the steel beams; each main room keeps 2 columns |
| **Roof needs only repairs and a coating** | – | −$279k | 13.9 yrs | Only if a roofer confirms the roof is sound |
| **Patch and reseal the parking lot instead of repaving** | – | −$202k | 14.0 yrs | Keep repaving for the worst areas |
| **Basic hall finishes ($20/SF less)** | −$11k | −$643k | 13.7 yrs | Simpler ceilings and lighting; décor rented per event |
| **Caterers bring and own the kitchen equipment** | −$6k | −$343k | 13.9 yrs | Kitchen shell, hoods and grease trap stay with the owners |
| **Insurance shopped 15% cheaper** | +$4k | – | 14.1 yrs | Tenants repay most of the insurance, so the owners keep little of the saving |

**Hybrid (Hall B in year 3).** Today: $903k profit a year on $13.86M; earns back in 15.3 years.

| Change (one at a time) | Profit each year | One-time money | Earns back in |
|---|---|---|---|
| **One more event a week across the halls (+52 a year)** | +$295k | +$14k | 11.6 yrs |

| Change (one at a time) | Profit each year | One-time money | Earns back in |
|---|---|---|---|
| **Charge $1,000 more per hall booking** | +$176k | – | 12.8 yrs |
| **Cater 10% more of the events in-house** | +$60k | – | 14.4 yrs |
| **Charge $5 more per guest for catering** | +$63k | – | 14.3 yrs |
| **Run the halls with $60,000 less year-round staff** | +$53k | – | 14.5 yrs |
| **Kids' center pays $6.00/SF instead of $4.50** | +$22k | +$20k | 15.0 yrs |
| **As-is space 85% leased instead of 75%** | +$43k | +$63k | 14.7 yrs |
| **Add a food pad on Summer Ave (about $70,000 a year of ground rent)** | +$57k | +$51k | 14.5 yrs |
| **Keep Hall A's columns and decorate around them** | – | −$410k | 14.9 yrs |
| **Roof needs only repairs and a coating** | – | −$279k | 15.0 yrs |
| **Patch and reseal the parking lot instead of repaving** | – | −$202k | 15.1 yrs |
| **Basic hall finishes ($20/SF less)** | −$7k | −$420k | 15.0 yrs |
| **Caterers bring and own the kitchen equipment** | −$3k | −$183k | 15.2 yrs |
| **Insurance shopped 15% cheaper** | +$4k | – | 15.3 yrs |

Small one-time increases on income changes come from a slightly larger loan and its interest while building.

**The other plans in brief:**

- **Full plan:** the hall changes are worth about the same in dollars: one more event a week adds $266k a year and $1,000 more per booking adds $170k. Keeping the columns saves about $0.83M, a roof that only needs coating about $593k, basic hall finishes about $634k, and caterer-owned kitchen equipment about $394k.
- **Lean hold:** getting the as-is space to 85% leased adds about $144k a year and brings the payback from 17.5 to 13.0 years. A food pad adds about $59k a year.
- **Lease everything:** no single change gets it under 21 years.

**The combined path to profit.** One more event a week across the halls, $1,000 more per booking, $60k less year-round staff, resealing instead of repaving the parking lot, and caterers bringing their own kitchen equipment, all buying at an assumed $3.0M:

| Combined path | Profit each year | Money to build it | Earns back in |
|---|---|---|---|
| **Efficient, open halls (columns removed)** | $1.67M | $14.71M | 8.8 years |
| **Efficient, columns kept** | $1.67M | $13.90M | 8.3 years |
| **Hybrid, open halls (columns removed)** | $1.50M | $13.55M | 9.0 years |
| **Hybrid, Hall A's columns kept (Hall B's removed in year 3)** | $1.50M | $13.14M | 8.7 years |
| **Full plan, open halls** | $1.67M | $17.99M | 10.8 years |

Keeping the columns saves about $0.8M in the efficient plan but leaves 2 columns in each main room, which the owners don't want.

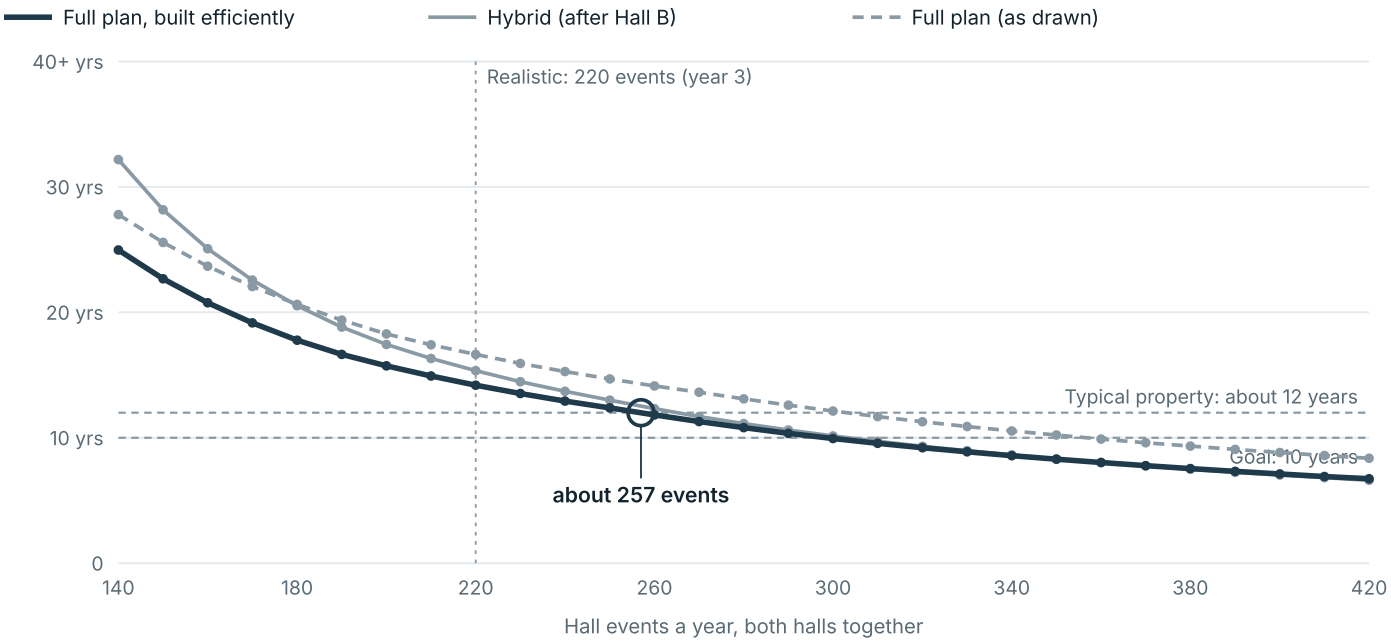
## What has to be true for the halls

The halls decide whether this works. The table shows how many events a year the two halls together would need for each plan to earn back all its money, buying at an assumed $3.0M, in 12 or 10 years, with everything else at the realistic numbers. Today's realistic case is 220 events a year: about 4 a week across both halls, or 2 per hall. That is a third-year number for a busy, mixed hall: a new hall typically books about 110–140 events in its first year and 170–200 in its second, because couples book their venue 12–18 months ahead. The best case assumes 260 events at higher prices and with more in-house catering.

| Plan | Earn back in 12 years | Earn back in 10 years (goal) |
|---|---|---|
| **Full plan, built efficiently** | 257 a year (about 5 a week) | 299 (about 6 a week) |
| **Hybrid (after Hall B)** | 265 (about 5 a week) | 303 (about 6 a week) |
| **Full plan (as drawn)** | 303 (about 6 a week) | 357 (about 7 a week) |

### The efficient plan needs about 257 events a year to earn back in about 12 years

Years to earn back all the money in, buying at an assumed $3.0M, against hall events a year for both halls together. Everything else at the realistic numbers.




Sycamore Square model v2.4, 18 Oct 2026 · realistic case · buying at an assumed $3.0M · hall events varied from 140 to 420 a year

- **In plain terms:** for the efficient plan to earn back in 12 years, buying at $3.0M, the two halls together need about 257 events a year. That is about 2½ events per hall every week of the year at today's assumed prices, about 17% more than the realistic case.
- **Prices do part of the work.** $1,000 more per booking is worth about as much as 31 extra events a year.
- **Splitting the rooms matters.** Two rooms have only 104 Saturdays a year between them, so most of the 220 events have to be smaller events on Fridays, Sundays and weekdays: weddings, quinceañeras, corporate, church, community and cultural events. The movable walls let each room host two of those at once.
- **The best case shows the prize.** At the best-case numbers (260 events, higher prices, more catering) the efficient plan earns back in about 4 years. Which case the market supports is the real question, and written

commitments from caterers, customers and a hall manager, gathered before any money is committed, are the way to find out.

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## New evidence since the first study

The biggest change is flood: the building's ground sits well above the flood level on most sides. That cuts the expected flood cost from $1.5M to about $0.2M at Memphis prices. Eight other findings also change the numbers; the last three are new in this version.

**1. Flood elevations (FEMA and USGS data, checked 18 October 2026)**

- **Base flood elevation:** FEMA's flood map (panel 47157C0311G, effective 6 February 2013) puts about 74% of the building in Zone AE. The flood source is Fletcher Creek, and the base flood elevation lines next to the building read 248 ft.
- **Ground around the building:** the USGS 1-meter lidar survey (flown in 2017) shows ground of 250–252 ft along about 85% of the walls. That is 2–4 ft above the flood level.
- **The weak spot:** about 240 ft of the rear wall, where the truck docks are, sits at 247.7–248.8 ft, roughly at flood level.
- **What Memphis requires:** a substantially improved building in the flood overlay needs its floor 24 inches above the flood level, which is 250 ft here. If the floor is near 251–252 ft, as the ground suggests, the building already meets that. The main flood cost becomes the survey, the paperwork and fixes at the dock area, not floodproofing the whole building.
- **Removing the building from the flood zone:** that would take a FEMA letter (LOMA). FEMA judges it by the lowest ground touching the building, so the dock area may block it unless that area is regraded or FEMA's exact flood profile there is lower. FEMA issued flood-map letters for three nearby properties in 2021: two buildings were taken out of the flood zone, and one was found to be outside it already.
- **Only a survey can confirm this.**

**2. County appraisal (Shelby County Assessor, 2026)**

- **Totals:** the four parcels are appraised at $4,928,100. The main parcel carries $1,364,500 of land and $2,994,800 of building.
- **Flood 50% rule:** using the assessor's building value, the threshold is about $1.5M of building work. Site work such as parking does not count. Every plan with halls passes that line, so flood compliance has to be designed in, which is cheap if the floor elevation is confirmed. An independent appraisal can set a higher building value.
- **Ownership and tax:** one company owns all four parcels. Today's tax is about $104,000 a year.

**3. Kids' center cost**

- **Indoor playground (soft play, climbing, party rooms):** much cheaper to build than a trampoline or ninja park. Kids Empire discloses $0.80–1.77M all-in for 15,000+ SF.
- **The trade-off:** a playground also takes in less, about $1.1M a year realistic against $1.55M for an active park.
- **What changed in the model:** the plans assume a playground operator paying about $4.50/SF plus its share of tax, insurance and upkeep. At that rent the operator keeps about $193k a year on roughly $1.1M invested, about 17.6% a year, and earns it back in about 5.7 years.

**4. Listing facts**

- **Vacancy:** the building was 51.4% leased when it was last marketed. It is now empty.
- **Parcels:** the 1717 frontage and 5810 Summer are also marketed on their own, so every plan here assumes all four parcels stay together. The county assessor lists the four parcels at 11.72 acres; the county's GIS map outlines add up to 11.88 acres, and a survey settles the difference.
- **Old quick-lube:** a permit dated 31 October 2024 (DEM-24-000379) demolished a 2,000 SF building with its footings on the frontage, which matches the old quick-lube.
- **Road work:** TDOT is widening Summer Avenue and replacing the Fletcher Creek bridge through mid-2028, which will disrupt the Summer Avenue frontage.
- **Stormwater rules:** the site is very likely inside the Fletcher Creek Overlay. New structures there, such as the convenience store, need floors 30 inches above the flood level, and new development needs stormwater detention.

**5. Interior columns (1997 drawings and new research)**

- **What is there:** the building's 1997 tenant drawings show roof columns on a grid of about 44.5 ft, with 2 columns inside each 11,000 SF hall room. Only those 4 come out; the columns in the kitchens and along the sides stay.
- **The fix:** remove them with steel beams about 89 ft long, with temporary supports while each column comes out and stronger footings under the columns that pick up the extra load. The budget is about $175k per column, $0.7M for all four (range $85k–300k per column), with the ownership group hiring the steel fabricator and structural engineer directly at Memphis prices. Steel itself runs about $5,800–6,450 a ton installed, or roughly $52k–91k per column. Delivered by a general contractor, the mid estimate is about $275k per column, and the closest documented job cost about $207k–480k per column.
- **It has been done before:** a Tulsa ice rink took 36 columns out of an empty mall department store; Christ Church of Northwest Arkansas removed 10 in a former Sears that later served as a call center; Eagle Brook Church opened a 1,000-seat room in a former Kmart; and Chelsea Piers Connecticut cleared 100-ft spans in an old factory.
- **Ceiling height:** the new beams hang below the roof. At least 15 ft of clear height under them would match the main Memphis wedding rooms: the Peabody Grand Ballroom is 15 ft 5 in, the Esplanade 15 ft and the Guest House at Graceland 17 ft.
- **Halls with columns still book:** The Columns at One Commerce Square in Memphis has 22 pillars, seats up to 800 and rents for $8,550 a day, and the Peabody still sells its rooms with columns for banquets. Premium venues advertise open rooms, though, and the owners want them.
- **Only a structural engineer on site can confirm** the roof framing, the footings and the clear height.

**6. Hall entrances on different sides (plans R4.2)**

- Hall A guests arrive from the east lot through the east wall. Hall B guests arrive from the south lot through the south-facing wall of the Hall B foyer, so the two arrivals no longer share a side of the building and two events can run at once without their guests crossing paths.

**7. What Memphis halls charge (venue rate cards, October 2026)**

- **Saturdays:** comparable halls ask about $7,000–9,000 for a 300–400 guest Saturday. The Palace at Cordova (12,000 SF, 300 seated) asks $7,000 on Saturday, $6,500 on Friday, $6,000 on Sunday and $5,500 Monday to Thursday, for 11 hours; The Columns $8,550; the Cadre Building $12,200; Memphis Botanic Garden's Hardin Hall $10,000 for 4 hours (2026 rates).

- **Other days:** Fridays and Sundays run about 80% of the Saturday rate and Monday to Thursday about 60%. Halls fill late dates at about half price (The Palace sells dates inside 30 days from $3,500).
- **Large rooms:** a full room for 650–700 guests rents for about $11,000–15,000 (Hilton's Tennessee Ballroom $15,000; The Kent up to $15,000). Hotels price through food-and-drink minimums instead: the Peabody asks $18,000–32,000.
- **Catering:** buffets run about $18–35 a guest and plated meals $28–52, plus a 20–24% service charge (Esplanade 20%, Westin 22%, Peabody 23%).
- **What the model uses:** $5,500 average room rental per event across all days (it was $4,750), $32 a guest for catering, and a 20% service charge, half paid to event staff.

**8. How many events a year (market research, October 2026)**

- **220 a year is a third-year number:** halls that host mixed events (weddings plus corporate, church and community events) do about 100–200+ events a year, and an average venue about 217; wedding-only venues do 30–60. Couples book their venue 12–18 months ahead, so a new hall needs about three years to fill.
- **Most events are smaller than these rooms:** the average wedding has about 117 guests (The Knot 2026), and two rooms have only 104 Saturdays a year between them. That is why each main room gets a movable wall, and why the realistic case now averages 300 guests per event instead of 350.
- **Few large halls nearby:** no hall outside the hotels seating 500 or more was found in northeast Memphis, Raleigh or Bartlett. The nearest are in Cordova and Germantown (FedEx Event Center, about 500 seated; Esplanade, 400) and downtown (The Kent, 600), and the 900-seat ballroom at the former Memphis Vitality Hotel has closed.
- **Who books:** weddings of every background, quinceañeras (about 1,100–1,200 girls in the metro area's Hispanic community turn 15 each year), corporate events, church and community events, and cultural celebrations. Shelby County records roughly 4,600–5,300 marriages a year.

**9. Building costs at Memphis prices, trade by trade (cost research, October 2026)**

- **Memphis is cheaper to build in:** the RSMeans 2025 city cost index puts Memphis at 89.4 against a 30-city average of 100.
- **A general contractor adds 11–22%:** general conditions run about 6–12% and overhead and profit the rest; RSMeans model costs carry 25% for contractor fees. Owners who manage the job and hire each trade directly typically save about 5–16% of the general contractor's price, closer to 20% when equipment is bought directly or used. The model plans on about 12%.
- **What can't be cut:** sprinklers for assembly use, the voice fire alarm, kitchen hoods and grease interceptors, restroom fixture counts, heating and air for large crowds, accessibility upgrades and structural engineering.
- **Unit costs checked:** roof coating $2–4/SF against $6–14/SF to tear off and replace; rooftop units $2,400–4,200 per ton installed; sprinkler work $4–12/SF; fire alarms $3–8/SF plus 30–50% for voice evacuation; kitchens $250–400/SF, with used equipment 30–60% cheaper.

## Where this could be too pessimistic, and too optimistic

The realistic case is a middle estimate built from public data, not from contractor quotes, surveys or signed tenants. These are the main reasons it could land higher or lower.

**Too pessimistic if:**

- **The floor is confirmed above 250 ft.** Lidar already points that way. Flood work then drops to the survey and dock-area fixes, and a FEMA map change could end mandatory flood insurance.
- **Trade prices come in under desk estimates.** The roof, heating and air, and parking lines are the biggest swing. County permits show about $250,000 of repairs in 2020 and a $424,000 alteration in 2012, so some systems may be newer than assumed. A roof that can be coated instead of replaced saves about $0.2–0.6M.
- **Prices reach the premium tier.** Once the halls have reviews, premium Memphis venues ask $10,000–12,000 for a 300–400 guest Saturday, and a full room for 650–700 guests rents for $11,000–15,000. The realistic case averages $5,500 per event across all days.
- **Hall demand beats 220 events a year.** Daytime and evening events on weekends, weekday corporate and church business, and lower off-peak prices can push bookings toward 260–300 once each room can be split. Large halls are thin in Jackson, MS, where the largest listed halls seat about 350. Each extra event a week across both halls adds about $295k a year of profit in the efficient plan, and at about 257 events a year it earns back in about 12 years.
- **Few large halls compete nearby.** No hall outside the hotels seating 500 or more was found in northeast Memphis, Raleigh or Bartlett, and the 900-seat Vitality ballroom has closed.
- **Cheaper financing applies.** SBA 504 loans need the owners' business to occupy at least 51% of an existing building, and they need far less cash down than a bank loan. The halls alone are about 37% of the building; if the owners' company also runs the kids' center, it reaches about 52%.
- **The outparcels earn money.** A food pad on Summer Avenue and a credit fuel tenant add $100–230k a year in the best case.
- **The columns come out for less.** The low estimate is about $85k per column ($0.34M for four) if the roof framing makes the job simple.

**Too optimistic if:**

- **Shops lease slowly.** Retail sits deep in the site behind other buildings, and Summer Avenue is under construction until mid-2028. Twenty-two small shops can take years to fill.
- **Large as-is blocks sit empty.** The building is empty; its last tenants left in the third quarter of 2026. 80,000–125,000 SF of space in one place leases slowly in Memphis, and big-box vacancy rose in 2026 as furniture stores left and IKEA announced its Cordova store would close.
- **Bookings start slow.** A new venue has no track record, and couples book 12–18 months ahead, so the first two years run well below 220 events. Mid-market Memphis halls fill Saturdays only 3–9 months ahead and discount late dates, and hotel ballrooms, the Esplanade and The Columns compete for large events.
- **Most events are smaller than these rooms.** The average wedding has about 117 guests. Without the movable walls that split each room, bookings could stay near 120–160 a year.
- **The building hides costs.** A 1984 building converting to assembly use can need more fire alarm, exit, restroom and electrical work than estimated. Contingency covers some of this, not all.
- **One contractor does the whole job, or trade-by-trade savings fall short.** Managing the trades directly moves coordination risk onto the owners. If the work goes to one general contractor, the efficient plan costs about $1.8M more and takes about 15.7 years instead of 14.2 to earn back.
- **Removing the columns is harder than assumed.** The steel beams need sound footings at their ends and enough height under the roof. The high estimate is about $300k per column, or $1.2M for all four (about $441k per column through a general contractor).
- **The crowd-size rule triggers earthquake work.** Under the building code Shelby County uses, a building whose large assembly rooms (each over 300 people) add up to more than 2,500 people moves into a

stricter safety class. For an existing building that can mean earthquake strengthening, and Memphis sits near the New Madrid fault, so this could cost more than the column work. With tables and chairs the two halls hold about 1,470 people, below the line. Chairs-only ceremony seating would cross it, and the kids' center and dining can count too. The fix is to cap each hall's posted capacity, confirmed by the City and a structural engineer before any commitment.

- **The flood answer goes the wrong way.** If the survey finds the floor below 250 ft, flood-proofing and insurance rise toward the worst case: about $0.85M of flood work instead of about $0.2M. The ground levels around the building make this unlikely.
- **The fuel pad stays empty.** At realistic volumes a fuel company would keep only about $4 a year for every $100 it spends on a roughly $3.8M station, and the frontage parcel is also marketed on its own. Without the fuel and food pads, the efficient plan takes about 15 years to earn back.

## Assumptions and sources

The realistic case is a middle estimate built from public data, research and the building's own records. It is not built from contractor quotes, surveys or signed tenants. These are the main inputs.

| What | Worst / realistic / best | Where it comes from |
|---|---|---|
| **Purchase price** | An assumed price of $3.0M in every case, plus fees, closing costs, surveys and inspections | The ownership group's planning assumption |
| **Building cost basis** | Memphis prices; the ownership group manages the work and hires each trade: 5% / 12% / 18% below one general contractor | RSMeans 2025 city cost index (Memphis 89.4); general contractor fees 11–22% (RSMeans, Construction Executive) |
| **Hall events, both halls together** | 120 / 220 / 260 a year (third-year level) | Mixed-use venues 100–200+ events a year, an average venue 217; about 60 / 110 / 130 per room |
| **Average room rental per event** | $4,000 / $5,500 / $7,250 | Memphis rate cards: The Palace at Cordova $7,000 Saturday to $5,500 weekdays; The Columns $8,550; Cadre $12,200; Fridays and Sundays about 80% and weekdays about 60% of Saturday |
| **In-house catering** | 35% / 55% / 60% of events; 250 / 300 / 380 guests; $25 / $32 / $35 a guest; service charge 18% / 20% / 22%, half paid to staff | Memphis buffets $18–35 and plated meals $28–52 a guest; service charges 20–24%; average wedding about 117 guests (The Knot 2026) |
| **Food and catering staff** | 66% / 59% / 57% of catering sales | Catering cost guides: food 28–35%, labor 25–35% |
| **Event-day staff (setup, cleaning, security)** | $1,300 / $1,200 / $1,150 per event | Includes security guards and set-up and clean-up, as premium Memphis halls include them |
| **Hall year-round costs** | about $0.69M / $0.62M / $0.58M a year, equipment leased | Our estimate: managers, sales, utilities at $2.50–3.00/SF, insurance |
| **Shop rent (efficient plan)** | $10.50 / $12.50 / $15.00 per SF plus a share of costs; 70% / 85% / 92% leased | Memphis 2026 average asking rent $14.20 (Marcus & Millichap); Shelby Crossing II $10–11 plus $3.68 of shared costs |
| **Flex rent** | $5.50 / $6.50 / $8.00 per SF; 50% / 75% / 90% leased | Cushman & Wakefield Memphis, Q3 2026: $7.49 citywide, $10.50 in the Northeast |
| **As-is space rent** | $4.25 / $5.75 / $7.25 per SF | Large-box asking rents in Memphis: about $3–9 |

| What | Worst / realistic / best | Where it comes from |
|---|---|---|
| **Kids' center rent** | $3.00 / $4.50 / $7.50 per SF plus a share of costs | Playground operator economics; Kids Empire discloses $0.80–1.77M to open 15,000+ SF |
| **Fuel pad ground rent** | $0 / $95k / $160k a year | Pad ground rents: regional operators $80–130k, credit tenants $150–200k (Murphy USA, Murfreesboro: $200k) |
| **Roof** | $10.99 / $5.48 / $1.46 per SF (full plan); $7.61 / $3.52 / $1.82 (efficient) | Silicone coating $2–4/SF; tear-off and replacement $6–14/SF (Construction Specifier, 2026) |
| **Heating and air** | about $2,960 / $2,190 / $1,680 per ton | Rooftop units $2,400–4,200 per ton installed (PickHVAC, 2026), at Memphis prices |
| **Fire alarm with voice evacuation** | $5.07 / $3.52 / $2.55 per SF | Fire alarms $3–8/SF for assembly use, plus 30–50% for voice evacuation |
| **Hall finishes and kitchens (efficient)** | $80 / $55 / $36 per SF and $338 / $235 / $164 per SF | Venue build-out $70–150/SF and kitchens $250–400/SF nationally, at Memphis prices, trade by trade |
| **Movable walls** | about $169k / $117k / $80k per main room | Allowance for an acoustic folding wall; a supplier quote is needed |
| **Column removal** | $300k / $175k / $85k per column | Cost build-up from 2025–26 steel prices without a general contractor's fee; contractor-delivered mid case $275k; closest documented job $207–480k per column |
| **Design, permits and contingency** | 14–24% of the building work | Design and permits 6–9%; renovation contingency 8–15% |
| **Property tax** | about 2.11% of appraised value a year | City $2.58081 plus county $2.70 per $100, assessed at 40% |
| **Insurance and upkeep** | $0.40–0.65/SF plus $10–40k of flood insurance; upkeep $1.15–1.75/SF | Our estimate; insurance quotes needed |

**What changed in this version (model v2.4).**

- Building costs are now at Memphis prices, with the ownership group managing the work and hiring each trade directly: about 12% below one general contractor in the realistic case. The cushion for surprises is unchanged, and the one-contractor version is shown for comparison.
- Column removal is budgeted at $175k per column ($0.7M for four), down from $275k ($1.1M) at contractor prices.
- Hall prices follow Memphis rate cards: $5,500 average room rental per event (was $4,750) and a 20% service charge on catering (new; half paid to event staff). Event-day staff rise to $1,200 per event to include security and set-up.
- Average guests per event fall to 300 (was 350), each main room gets a movable wall so it can host smaller events, and 220 events a year is treated as a third-year number for a mixed hall.

**What changed since the first study.** An independent review of the money model led to these corrections:

- Loans are now sized the way a lender would size them. This changes the cash the owners put in, not the profit before loan payments.
- The halls now set money aside to replace furniture and equipment, or lease them.
- Hall finishes and kitchens are raised to research levels ($70/SF and $300/SF at national contractor prices in the efficient plan, up from $50 and $225).
- The fire alarm is upgraded to voice evacuation, which crowds over 1,000 require.

- Column removal is added for the 4 columns inside the two hall rooms.
- The kids' center rent is lowered to $4.50/SF, so the operator still earns about 17.6% a year (about $193k after rent on $1.1M).
- Building costs during construction are no longer counted twice, and property tax is capped at what the finished building is worth.
- The hybrid now counts Hall B's own slow start and the as-is rent it gives up while Hall B is built.
- Fuel margins are updated to industry figures, and the fuel pad is flagged as uncertain.
- Results are shown in plain money terms (years to earn back, profit for every $100 spent) instead of finance ratios.

**Sources**

- FEMA Flood Map Service Center and USGS 3D Elevation Program: flood map and ground levels
- Shelby County Assessor, parcel 088066 00027: appraisal, building size, permits
- 44 CFR 65.5: FEMA map-change rules
- TDOT, Summer Avenue widening
- Hall prices: The Palace at Cordova rate card, The Historic Cadre Building, Memphis Botanic Garden 2026 rates, The Kent, The Columns at One Commerce Square, Esplanade Memphis and The Peabody
- Demand: The Knot 2026 Real Weddings Study, US wedding venue market report (MMCG, 2026), events a year at a typical venue (ProjectionHub), Memphis venue capacities (Memphis Magazine, August 2025) and CDC state marriage rates
- The Peabody capacity chart and The Guest House at Graceland: ceiling heights and rooms with columns
- Catering menu pricing (Galley Solutions) and BizBuySell catering benchmarks: catering costs and margins
- Kids Empire franchise disclosure (Franzy): playground opening costs
- Marcus & Millichap, Memphis retail Q3 2026, Shelby Crossing II and CityFeet Memphis listings: shop and box rents
- Cushman & Wakefield, Memphis industrial Q3 2026: flex rents
- Murphy USA ground lease, Murfreesboro and NACS key metrics 2026: fuel pad rent and fuel margins
- Building costs: RSMeans city cost index, Q4 2025, RSMeans model costs and contractor fees, general conditions 6–12% (Construction Executive), silicone coating vs. tear-off (Construction Specifier, 2026), rooftop unit cost per ton (PickHVAC, 2026) and steel supply and erection (Linbeck, Q3 2025)
- Venue build-out costs (Dojo Business) and tenant improvement costs (Terrapin): hall and kitchen fit-out
- Contingency for renovations (ConstructConnect)
- Column removal: Retail to Rinks, Tulsa (Modern Steel Construction), Christ Church of NWA (MBL Architects), Eagle Brook Church Anoka (BWBR), Chelsea Piers Connecticut (WSP) and Crossgates column-removal costs (ProCM)
- Crowd-size and earthquake rule: 2021 IBC structural changes (STRUCTURE magazine), Shelby County 2021 IBC with local amendments and USGS Memphis seismic hazard maps

Public version: transaction terms are omitted. Every number includes buying the property at an assumed price of $3.0M, plus fees, closing costs, surveys and inspections. Everything here comes from public records, desk research and concept-level estimates; it is not legal, engineering or investment advice.